How an Influencer Built His Business, One Dog at a Time

Podcast: Wall street journal

AI Executive Summary

Core Thesis The episode explores the complex reality behind the "influencer" lifestyle by profiling Elias Friedman, known as "The Dogist." While social media stardom appears to be an effortless pursuit of passion, true success in the $250 billion creator economy requires intense professional adaptation, the ability to manage a diversified business portfolio beyond simple content creation, and the resilience to navigate shifting algorithms and mental health challenges.

Key Arguments & Data * **The Economics of Influence:** * The global influencer economy is valued at over $250 billion and is expected to continue growing (Goldman Sachs, 2023). * There is extreme wealth disparity within the industry: 48% of creators earn $15,000 or less annually, while only 13% earn more than $100,000. * For established creators like The Dogist, the most lucrative revenue stream is large-scale brand partnerships rather than direct fan funding or commissions. * **Algorithmic Evolution & Content Strategy:** * Early Instagram growth (circa 2013) relied on high organic reach where posts were shown to most followers; modern algorithms are more restrictive, requiring creators to "retool" their approach. * Shrinking attention spans have necessitated a shift from static photography to video content that utilizes an immediate "hook"—often showing the end result of a video at the beginning to retain viewers. * Successful long-term creators must pivot from being purely "behind the camera" (photographers) to becoming "on-camera" personalities to satisfy the demand for video and human connection. * **The Business of Content Creation:** * The workload of a successful creator is rarely purely creative; Friedman estimates that only about one-third of his time is spent on actual photography/creative work, with the remaining two-thirds dedicated to business management, editing, and logistics. * Sustainability depends on diversification across multiple channels: books, apparel, podcasts, YouTube shows, and merchandise. * **Mental Health & Professional Pressures:** * Digital creators face significantly higher rates of anxiety, depression, and burnout compared to the general population (Harvard study). * The "always-on" nature of the job—often requiring seven-day work weeks—and

the necessity of managing public judgment are significant psychological stressors.

Actionable Takeaways * **Prioritize Diversification:** For anyone building a personal brand, do not rely on a single platform or revenue stream (e.g., Instagram ads). Build an ecosystem that includes owned media (newsletters/websites), physical products (books/apparel), and secondary platforms (YouTube/Podcasts) to protect against algorithm volatility. * **Master the "Hook" Strategy:** In any digital communication or marketing effort, assume a low attention span. Structure information so that the most engaging or impactful element is presented immediately to prevent users from scrolling past. * **Adopt an Entrepreneurial Mindset toward Passion:** If turning a hobby into a career, prepare for the transition from "creator" to "manager." Success requires building a support infrastructure (agents, assistants, managers) and treating the creative output as a product within a larger business framework. * **Leverage Brand Alignment:** For marketers looking to engage with influencers, seek out those whose mission aligns with your brand values. As seen with The Dogist, the value lies in the creator's ability to foster a deep, emotional connection between their niche audience and the featured products.

Full Transcript

A few weeks ago, I met up with Elias Friedman in a park in Manhattan. I brought my dog, Picasso, along with me. Elias set us up on a bench to take our portrait. Anywhere in the shade, it could even be up on the bench here. Sure. That's easy. All right. Picasso, you want to go back up here? Elias is better known as the dogist. Oh, you're a good boy. For over a decade, he's made a career out of taking beautiful pictures of dogs, mostly around New York.

and posting them on social media. On Instagram, Elias has seven and a half million followers. Watching him work is kind of funny. He holds a squeaky ball above the camera lens. He squeals, howls, and grunts to get Picasso's attention. These are some of the techniques Elias has honed over more than a decade of doing this. So those are some good moves there. You're moving your arm around. Yeah. You kind of have to keep their attention one way or another. So fast movements. You have to entertain them a little bit. And you have to pay him for his work. Elias has Picasso eating out of his hand, literally. There's a bag of doggy treats on his waist, which he doles out as a reward for sitting still. Picasso is nailing poses I've never seen him do before. Taking photos of dogs isn't the only thing Elias does in running the doggest, but it's definitely the best thing. He walks around New York City with a camera in his hand.

getting to meet hundreds of the city's furry residents. I feel like I fulfilled a childhood dream. Like, I'm getting to live my inner childhood every day. Like, everyone's like, what if I could walk around every day and meet people's dogs? That's something you would write in kindergarten with crayons. Yeah, yeah. And a lot of people, that's not what they end up doing. And for me, it is what ended up happening. Elias is an influencer. A job that didn't exist two decades ago. But it is now one of the most desired jobs out there, especially for young people. According to one poll from 2023, more than half of Gen Zers said they want to be a social media influencer. It's a job that sounds appealing. Influencers can seemingly do what they love, post about it online, and make a living. But is it really that easy? How does

it actually work? From the journal This Is Work Mode, a special series airing on Sundays, where we take a look at how work is changing.

I'm Ryan Knudsen. Let's get to work. I met up with Elias Freedman, aka the Doggest, in Madison Square Park in downtown Manhattan. It was morning, jazz bands were playing, and people were out walking their dogs. I wanted to talk to Elias because he's one of the OG influencers, and he's been really successful. Also, I love dogs. And my first question is, what do you think of my dog? Picasso? Yeah, Picasso down here. Five out of five, or no. 10 out of 5. There we go. That's what we're looking for. He's a perfect pup. He's a really good boy. And, well, with a name like that, he's got a lot to live up to. All right, so this is kind of like a job profile interview, so I want to kind of get into the details of how you've built this really successful media business off the back of these dogs. So can you just tell us the story of how this idea for the doggies got started? Yes. Well, I think you have to include my origin story when I was a kid.

Growing up with a dark room in the house and two Labrador retrievers, my dad was a hobbyist photographer. So I sort of was inspired by my dad to do photography, to do portrait work, and dogs were the first subject. And I was kind of shy so dogs were easy to get to sit if you had a tree. Dog photography didn't become Elias' full-time job until it got laid off in 2013 from a brand strategy agency. At the time, Instagram was in its infancy. It had only been out for a few years, and being an influencer was a new kind of job. Elias was inspired by accounts like Humans of New York and the Sartorialist, which featured portraits of New York's human residents. And I just said, no one's doing this for dogs. So you actually set out to do this as a job. That was kind of your intention. I thought it could be. I first saw it as something really fun and would bring the world some joy.

and it'll be a little bit of a joke, right? It's like, dogs don't want their pictures taken, but I make it seem like they do. What do dogs don't want their picture taken? Are they hard to photograph? Well, some dogs are hard to photograph, especially puppies. But dogs don't, they don't have an ego. They don't have a sense of what cameras are or that they could be depicted. They don't have a sense, they don't have that thing that we have. They're not burdened by an ego, so... Whenever you take a picture of a dog, you're just

seeing a pure expression, whereas when you take a picture of a person, you're seeing some contortion of reality. Right. How did it go in the early days? Walk me through what it was like as you were starting to build this out from zero followers in the beginning. I think from the first day, October 23, 2013, I knew it would be something. Honestly, it got traction very quickly. Turns out people like dogs, and I was taking the best pictures of them.

And I think I'm still pretty good at that. And so I launched it and then within a month they got picked up by various outlets and people were calling to represent me and getting a book deal. Wow, within a few months? Yeah, like within a year it hit a million followers, which is a lot. Yes, that's a lot of you. And it was, I would say it was like sort of like a gold rush era of Instagram of being able to scale quickly. It didn't surprise me that people love dogs. What did that actually look like? Like every time you'd open your phone, there'd be thousands of new followers? Yeah, it was me on the couch in Williamsburg refreshing, watching new followers come in, people liking my pictures, and like, this is something. I'm not surprised that people love dogs, but this is gonna be a thing. How did that feel? It felt awesome. And it was something I love to do, right? It was adventurous.

It still is, obviously, but I was walking around wearing knee pads under my pants with my pockets filled with dog treats, and I was walking around the best day in the world in New York and hanging out with dogs, getting their pictures and getting their stories, and everyone started to catch on to it, and they were thrilled to be featured. But my parents were still very dubious of the path I was on, because they're both physicians. It's more of a predictable path. A lot more schooling. Yeah. I just wasn't really cut out for that. But I think when I got my first book deal where it was like a chunk of change and like validation that this is more than just a silly Instagram account, that was like, okay, this is like, this could have bigger opportunity to become a business. As his following grew, Elias started to make some real money. He partnered with dog brands to feature their products in his posts. He also got that book deal, which featured a thousand of his dog photos.

So it took you one year to get to a million followers. How long did it take before he was actually like paying your rent in the bills? I think around

then, you know, I'm still kind of the only person that does what I do. And so I've always had some form of brand partnership going on. And, you know, it's very volatile at scales. And so, you know, it's not like I'm raking it in, so to say, but It was enough to support me and to get by and make it work. How much of your success do you credit to just being early in the very beginning of when Instagram was really taking off like you were there? I will say that my timing was good in that if I tried to start it now, it would be much harder to grow a larger audience. Why do you think that is? I think the algorithms are less... It's harder to scale that algorithms don't show your work as predictably.

whereas back when I started, every post I made, every person in my audience saw them, whereas now, some people see them. So it's just harder to get views, I guess. Social media has changed a lot since Elias started The Dogist in 2013. As Elias said, the algorithm has a bigger influence now over what you see in your feed. And on top of that, there are so many more influencers competing for your attention, which makes breaking out and making a living through social media Harder. Platforms are also much more focused on video these days. And it's more important for influencers to be on camera themselves. For Elias, that meant featuring something that is not a dog in his feed. Himself. And so there was a moment, an inflection point where I had to come out from behind the curtain, so to say. And it wasn't just me as a photographer, but me as a person. And who am I? Who is Elias? Like I am saying hi to you right now.

When was that moment? Do you remember that? And what did that feel like? I think that was about seven or eight years ago. It was a bit scary because change is hard. And I didn't know that wasn't the plan initially, right? It was like, I want to be a really good photographer. And I grew up as a shy kid. I still am in many ways very shy. And so there was like a question mark like, now you're looking at me. Do you like me? Or is it just my dog pictures? Did you feel like you had to refine the way you presented yourself as you went through that process? Yeah, I think, you know, there's something, there's a skill, there's a knack to hosting or being a personality and being entertaining. And so with anything, just take some practice and you have your own unique way of doing it. And I don't know, some people

think I'm funny. Some people like the way I interact with dogs. And that's all that matters.

What kind of a challenge is the algorithm presenting now? Like what is the thing that you're noticing that you're having to pivot toward or change? I think it can be challenging with all the new tools that come out every week, it seems like. And working with a shorter time frame. Like now people's attention spans have shrunken to something like a second, two seconds. So now it's all about the hook. Right. People won't just watch your video. You've got to make sure that you keep on getting instantly. You've got to get them in. And it's almost like you've got to show them the end before you start. Like I said, people's attention spans have become nothing. And so you have to just retool the way that you show your work. And it can't just be, instead of being frustrated about it, you have to just lean into it and adapt and change it up. After the break, we talk about the money.

and whether there are any downsides to being an influencer. Globally, roughly 50 million people make money as social media influencers, according to a report from Goldman Sachs in 2023. The whole influencer economy is now worth more than 250 billion, and the bank says that number is expected to grow. That money can come from brand deals, affiliated marketing commissions, or from fan funding sites like Patreon, but it's often not enough to make a living. 48% of creator earners made 15,000 or less, and only 13% made more than 100,000. That's according to a marketing agency survey from 2023. That means influencers often have to diversify and look for new ways to make money. Elias has also had to diversify. For instance, last year he launched a YouTube show where he finds dogs to photograph with the help of celebrity guests.

The doggies has grown into just obviously more than an Instagram account. You've got books, apparel, podcasts, YouTube show. Which is the most lucrative of these different channels? I would say partnering with a brand who are a big company and they want to invest in their marketing. That generally is, I've found to be the most lucrative. How much money have you made doing this as a profession? I don't know, it's hard to say. I've been doing it for 14 years. So, I don't know, you have to ask, that's my accountant. Yeah, listen, I'll say this. I live comfortably in a very expensive

city, Manhattan, in Chelsea, in one bedroom with one dog and my wife. And I get to have a nice lifestyle and a nice Japanese car, a Subaru. But not enough to retire now if you wanted to. No.

Not enough, you gotta keep working. No, I mean, in a way I feel like I've been retired in some way, like I really thoroughly enjoy what I do. My goal, when I set out as an entrepreneur, I wasn't like, I'm gonna make so much money. I was like, I found the thing that will make the world a better place. And I know that I will be able to support myself because brands who do make millions of dollars, billions of dollars, whatever, they will want to support me in that mission. How many employees do you have? What does your business sort of look like in terms of scale? I have basically a team of people that support me. No one who's full-time, but I have a management team, I have literary agents, I have assistants, I have social media managers, and so it fluctuates a little bit but that's the current setup and I couldn't do it without them because it is a lot of work. Even though it's amazing work, it's a lot of work.

How many hours a week are you working? I mean, I work seven days a week all day. That's the jewel. I wouldn't say it's a trade-off. It's a privilege to get to do what I get to do, but it requires constant maintenance. And just to say, being an influencer can be a real grind. You have to be posting constantly. And for some, the pressure of putting their lives in front of tens of thousands of people and the judgment that can come with that can really take a toll on their mental health. There was a Harvard study from late last year that found higher rates of anxiety, depression, and burnout among digital creators compared to the general population. In terms of the job itself, is there a lot of pressure to be a content creator, essentially? Yes, it can be a lot of pressure. But that pressure is a privilege. And you learn to have fun with it and get better at it and enjoy it.

It's worth it because you sort of discover new parts of yourself and new ways to, like I said, make the world a better place. How often did people say no when you asked to photograph their dog? I would say people say no one out of ten times. But you don't get to see that because they said no. Did you have to learn how to deal with rejection better because of that? Yes. It doesn't feel good to be rejected, but it also is humbling in a good way.

because, like I said, it keeps me humble. I would say that I get recognized all the time now. People say, oh, I love your work. And you know what people say, which is not to sound narcissistic, but people say I love you. And I know that they don't mean that they love me. I know they mean that I love what you're doing. But it's got to feel pretty good. Of course. What a lovely thing to say.

And that's inspiration for me to keep doing what I do and that I'm making a difference in the world. What percentage of your time are you spending doing the actual creative work versus everything else that goes on behind the scenes? That's a good question. I would say a third of the time I'm doing creative work. Sometimes half the time, but that's my favorite part of it. As you would imagine is walking around like we are today. This is literally a walk in the park. and creating my artwork and then going back and uploading it and editing pictures and creating little narratives like that's pretty fun. And then a lot of it is figuring out the business side of things like how to support continuing to do that. So you said that when you were a kid you know 9, 10 or whatever taking photos of dogs and you're like oh no one this is not a job. Yeah. What do you think that your childhood self would think of what you've done with your career? I am.

I think my child itself would be really happy and impressed and grateful that you did something that took some kutzpa, like some leap of faith because a lot of people will, you know, I was sort of lucky to have been let go for my job because if I hadn't, then I probably would have stayed in that path. You know, you always take the path of least resistance. And so I was fortunate to have had the opportunity to try something back in 2013 and I had a good feeling about it. I figured it out, luckily, pretty quickly that this would be a thing and I could support myself. Great. Anything else you want to add? Thank you for loving your dogs. My goal is to deepen people's appreciation for their dogs because dogs make our lives better and so we should make their lives better. When you're around a dog, everything else goes away. They bring you into this present moment.

and we need more of that nowadays. Work Mode is a series from The Journal, a co-production of Spotify and The Wall Street Journal. This episode is produced by Enrique Perez de la Rosa and edited by Katherine

Brewer and Laura Morris. I'm Ryan Knudson, special thanks to Picasso for being a good boy during this interview. If you want to see a picture of him, you can check out my Instagram, at ryanknudson, where you'll also find a fun video of me and Elias playing the World Cup of Dogs. We'll be back next Sunday with our next episode in the series until then have an amazing week. I hope it's not too rough on you